

Early Islamic art

The Muslim era began officially in 622 CE, the year of the prophet Muhammad's flight from Mecca to Medina. Islam spread quickly throughout the Mediterranean, Asia and parts of Africa. As Arab culture spread, indigenous artistic traditions were absorbed, and Muslim art developed as an amalgamation of various styles. Under the Umayyad Dynasty (661–750), magnificent mosaic-embellished architecture was constructed, including the Dome of the Rock in Jerusalem in 691. The decorative arts continued to flourish under the Abbasid Dynasty (750–1258) notably in glassware, pottery, metalwork and textiles, featuring bright colours and 'arabesques;' rhythmic patterns resembling plant tendrils. Many shapes and patterns have symbolic significance. Although Muhammad's teaching does not ban representational art, the Qur'an states that there 'is nothing like a likeness of Him', resulting in the Islamic tradition of not depicting people or animals, although there are some exceptions. As the Qur'an is central to the art, calligraphy has always been an essential aspect, as have geometry, spirituality and a sense of rhythm.



Dome of the Rock, Jerusalem, 689–91 CE